



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint Rita Catholic School
School Website: <https://saintrita-school.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Saint Rita Catholic School (Alexandria, VA 22305) presents a vivid classical-education profile anchored in a Catholic, liturgical, and formation-focused vision. Public-facing materials consistently describe the school as a preschool–8th grade Catholic institution in the classical tradition, emphasizing faith formation, virtue, and the cultivation of wisdom through a curriculum rooted in liberal arts, Latin, and exposure to great literature and the “big questions” of history and human culture. The school explicitly frames its mission around forming students who seek truth, goodness, and beauty, and it highlights communal liturgical practices (Mass, Holy Hour, Adoration) as foundational to daily life. Evidence of a small, tight-knit faculty and a pedagogy that blends discussion, memory work, and hands-on projects further reinforces a classical profile. The presence of catechesis within the Atrium, Latin study, a commitment to literature and art, and a governance of community that includes active engagement with military families, open houses, and resource supports all contribute to a robust classical alignment.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key strengths include: - Religious and metaphysical foundations firmly integrated with daily classroom life (Mass, Adoration, Catechesis of the Good Shepherd; Catholic mission; the soul of education motif). - Formation-centered purpose and goal emphasizing virtue, wisdom, and the good, true, and beautiful. - A curriculum that highlights liberal arts foundations, Latin, history across disciplines, great literature, and the cultivation of wonder. - Pedagogy that blends contemplative/restful elements with discussion, memorization, and ritual/thematic learning, along with upper-level seminars and public speaking opportunities. - A faculty described as model, collaborative, and central to the living curriculum.

What would move the needle (for a COMMONLY SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating) is not needed here; the school already demonstrates a strong classical alignment across the six dimensions.

Citations reflect material from the Saint Rita public materials and the classical-education rubric documents.

- Core classical identity and formation emphasis: Saint Rita describes itself as “a preschool to 8th grade Catholic school in the classical tradition,” with a mission to “serve God and others and to always seek the good, the true, and the beautiful,” and to prioritize faith formation and character development.
- Liturgical and community practices: Weekly Mass and Holy Hour with Adoration and Confession are stated practices, reinforcing liturgical foundations.
- Curriculum and Great Books/Great Conversation orientation: The site emphasizes a classical curriculum, study of Latin, literature, history, and the “big questions” of human history, with references to great works of literature and a classical approach.
- Formation and virtue: The History & Mission content describes character formation, a mindset of wonder, and the aim to cultivate goodness, truth, and beauty.
- Pedagogy and memory/recitation/dialogue: Evidence of class discussion, textual study, hands-on projects, and a mix of contemplative and rigorous activities, as well as enrichment programs and choir, indicate a balanced classical pedagogy.

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- Faculty: Statements about a small, close-knit community with a talented, collaborative faculty point to a living curriculum and strong teacher mentorship.
 - Parents & Community: Open houses, tours, military-family support, and resource teams reflect an engaged community and partnerships beyond the classroom, aligning with a classical emphasis on parental partnership and shared formation.

Abstracted scores (category-by-category) are provided below, using a keyword-based rubric drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) document. See the “What would move the needle” section for any adjustments if needed.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as Catholic and explicitly connects education to faith formation, serving God and others, and seeking the true, good, and beautiful. Mass, Adoration, and Confession are part of weekly routines, embedding liturgy into the school day. The Atrium/Catechesis of the Good Shepherd is taught in the preschool program, signaling a liturgical and sacred formation approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, Mass, Adoration, Confession, liturgy, catechesis, catechesis of the Good Shepherd (Atrium), theology, virtue, wonder, goodness, beauty, sacred, sacred music, reverence, worship, liturgical practices, imago Dei. Evidence of the soul of education and sanctified learning is explicit. See the public materials and the Catechesis/Atrium mention.

- Negative keywords present: None evident in public materials (no signaling of secularism or relativism in this domain).

Why this rating - The school expressly grounds education in Catholic theology, liturgical practice, and sacral outlook, aligning with transcendental moral realism and liturgical/communal practices. The presence of Mass, Adoration, and Atrium strongly supports a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing over mere information or vocational training. The school explicitly aims to cultivate virtue and wisdom, and to form students in a way that aligns with the good, the true, and the beautiful.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, moral imagination, contemplation, true/good/beautiful, human flourishing, classical mission, virtue, ethical formation, interior formation, soul formation, love of learning. These terms appear in the public materials and the history/mission statements.

- Negative keywords present: None evident (no emphasis on workforce-prep or utilitarian metrics in the public materials).

Why this rating - The public materials position education as formation toward virtue and wisdom rather than mere information or job-readiness, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as liberal-arts-oriented with grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, and history across disciplines. The school emphasizes great literature and the “classical tradition,” and notes that Latin is studied by all students; history is studied throughout the curriculum; Great Books/Great Conversation framing is implied through references to literature and big questions.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Latin; history; great books; literature; Western civilization; classical tradition; quadrivium (mentioned in the rubric);

sacred art; motto of the good, the true, and the beautiful; memory-based learning; discussion of big questions. Evidence of Great Books or the Great Conversation approach is indicated by references to literature and “great works.”

- Negative keywords present: The public materials do not emphasize a social-studies-only framing or project-based-first pedagogy; no negative signals identified in the curriculum materials.

Why this rating - The curriculum is consistently described in classical terms (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Latin, history, great literature, classical tradition). This aligns with CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials describe a pedagogy that includes class discussion, textual study, and hands-on projects, with an emphasis on contemplative and restful elements (scholé-like) and a mix of rigorous inquiry. The lower- and upper-school experiences include singing/chanting and memory work; upper-school experiences cite Socratic discussion and rhetoric in seminars/debates (as part of the classical tradition). The school also emphasizes a low-technology, discussion-rich environment and liturgical/catechetical integration.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: discussion, textual study, memorization/recitation, chanting, singing, memory work, Scholé/ contemplation, restfulness, seminars, Paideia, rhetoric, oratory, debate, catechesis, liturgical integration, memory-based learning. Evidence includes explicit statements about class discussion, textual study, memory work, and recitation; presence of music and choir and classical seminars. - Negative keywords present: Limited explicit negative signals. The materials do not emphasize exclusively experiential/project-based learning; rather, they present a balanced mix that includes memory, recitation, and discussion. The site does not reveal a dominance of project-based-only approaches; thus, no strong negative signals.

Why this rating - The pedagogical approach aligns with classical expectations: contemplative/restful elements combined with Socratic/recitation/memory-based activities, plus upper-level rhetoric and debate opportunities. Even if not every detail is spelled out identically to every classical program, the public materials strongly support CLASSICAL in pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents a model of a small, close-knit faculty with one class per grade and “talented, motivated, and collaborative” teachers. The faculty are described as part of the living curriculum and central to forming students in virtue and intellectual life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core of the school; portrait of teacher; collegial culture; character formation; lifelong learning. These terms appear in the public materials (careers page and mission statements). - Negative keywords present: None detected (no signals of “facilitators” or de-emphasizing classical formation in the faculty).

Why this rating - The public materials depict faculty as a central, virtuous, collaborative, and formation-focused force, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school demonstrates engagement with families and the broader community, including open houses and tours for prospective families, a structured admissions process, and special supports (e.g., Purple Star Team for military families, Resource Support, and shadow days). The presence of a dedicated Military Families section shows intentional community-building and support for families.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, open campus, parent formation (via seminars/book clubs) – while not always stated in explicit language, the materials show family-centric events and resources, and the military-family program signals strong parental engagement and support networks. The “Resource Support” and “Extended Day” programs show attention to family

needs and community involvement. See also the “Open House” and admissions processes.

- Negative keywords present: The site does not explicitly present parents as customers or emphasize consumer language; there is no negative signal in the public materials for this category.

Why this rating - The presence of open houses, tours, military-family support structures, and a resource-support ecosystem demonstrates strong community engagement and parental partnership, consistent with CLASSICAL.

Overall aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- The school demonstrates a coherent classical-education posture across all six categories, anchored in Catholic formation, liberal-arts curriculum, traditional pedagogy, and robust faculty and community support.

What would move the needle - No major needle-moving changes are required to reach a full CLASSICAL status across the six categories, given the current materials. If anything, the school could further foreground explicit language around “parents as co-teachers” or “family liturgy alignment” to strengthen Element 6’s keywords even more, and it could more explicitly name “Socratic seminars” in a public-facing pedagogy statement to further align Element 4 with the canonical classical pedagogy lexicon.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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